then becomes whether we do that by a sudden, unannounced strike of some sort, or we build up the crisis to the point where the other side has to consider very seriously about giving in, or even Cubans themselves take some action on this." Rusk had set the agenda for the discussion for hours and days to come. There was an unspoken agreement in the room that the missiles had to go, no matter what. The question now was whether to give priority to diplomacy or military action.

Rusk believed that a strike was justified if the military situation did not allow time for diplomacy. The strike could be executed on its own or as part of an invasion of the island. But if time allowed, Rusk favored diplomacy, which would include informing if not consulting with US allies in Europe as well as Latin American clients and partners. He was also in favor of approaching Castro and pointing out to him that Khrushchev had victimized Cuba by putting ballistic missiles on the island and opening it to American intervention. He also wanted to let Khrushchev know that "there is an utterly serious crisis in the making here." He added: "Mr. Khrushchev may not himself really understand that or believe that at this point."[11]

As the discussion moved into the evaluation of pros and cons of the options proposed by Rusk, Kennedy wondered how much time he had to decide on a course of action before the information about the discovery of the missiles was leaked to the media or to his opponents in Congress. Secretary of Defense Robert McNamara gave the president one week: "[W]e should assume that this will become fairly widely known, if not in the newspapers, at least by political representatives of both parties." Rusk was in agreement: Senator Keating had already been talking about the construction of intermediate-missile launch sites on October 10. Presumably, he had obtained his information from Cuban refugees.[12] Shockingly, the time frame for the decision was decided not on the basis of how soon the Soviets would be able to make their missiles operational, but on the assumption of how long the news could be kept secret.

Whether the time frame was one week or two, Kennedy could not count on having much time before he had to act. But what action should he take? As the discussion progressed, Rusk's two options, strike and diplomacy, turned in Kennedy's mind into four: a surgical air strike against ballistic missiles; a general air strike against all types of missiles and the Soviet air